

later life) was born in December 1865 in the small town of Hämeenlinna in Finland, a region that until 1918 was a Grand Duchy of Czarist Russia. The educated classes—among them Johan’s parents—were generally Swedish-speaking; the broader population spoke Finnish, which was increasingly associated with a spirit of growing national unease and restlessness at Russian political domination.

Early struggles and success

Sibelius’s father was a doctor, who died in a typhoid epidemic when Johan was only two, leaving Maria Sibelius, his pregnant young widow, a mountain of debts. Maria took her family to live with her mother elsewhere in Hämeenlinna. They could not afford to give the three children an elite, Swedish-speaking education, so Johan was sent to a local Finnish-speaking school. In 1885, aged 20, having graduated from high school, Sibelius moved to Helsinki and studied violin at the Music Institute. During his time there, he adopted his father’s feckless habits and struggled with debt and drinking issues for the next four decades.

His dream of becoming a virtuoso violinist was tempered as a result of his friendship with Ferruccio Busoni, the master-pianist who taught at the Institute. Realizing that this level of performance would be beyond him, Sibelius spent a year as a promising student-composer in Berlin, then another in Vienna. But he could never have envisaged the astonishing success of his first major work, *Kullervo*, when he conducted its premiere in Helsinki in 1892. In this work, Sibelius tells the story of the principal character in the *Kalevala*, the Finnish folk epic, in the